THE VIETNAM WAR

THE POPULAR IMAGE of the Vietnam War is of foot-slogging search-and-destroy operations. The impression does little justice to the key US and South Vietnamese naval operations during the decade-long conflict. US involvement in the Vietnam War began in earnest at sea with the Gulf of Tonkin engagement in 1964, and ended with major evacuations from the South Vietnamese coastline in 1975. In between were a huge range of maritime operations. Aircraft carrier groups sat at two locations off the Vietnamese coast ("Yankee Station" and "Dixie Station") to launch naval air strikes against North Vietnam and Viet Cong targets in South Vietnam. Navy and Coast Guard units cut Communist supply lines during Operation Market Time, while a composite US Navy and US Army "Brown Water Navy" fought the Communists along the waterways of the Mekong Delta. Vietnam also saw more traditional forms of naval warfare, with the battleship *New Jersey* deployed to provide fire support to ground troops with her huge 16-in guns. Although the Vietnam War ultimately ended in defeat for the West, the efforts of the US maritime forces were arguably the most successful component of the war.

RIVERINE OPERATIONS

The Mekong River Delta in South Vietnam was home to over 50 percent of the country's population during the Vietnam war and contained the most fertile rice-producing land. It was also laced with 3,000 miles (4,800 km) of tangled, jungle-shrouded waterways that provided superb covert transportation lanes for Communist insurgents, the Viet Cong, to traffic people, supplies, and weapons. Taking the war to the Viet Cong along the Mekong was the task of the "Brown Water Navy" a collection of US Army, Navy, and South Vietnamese riverine patrol units.

The first unit tasked with patrolling the Mekong was the River Patrol Force (RPF), established in 1965. In terms of vessels, US forces made use of almost anything that could float and be armed, including World War II-era landing craft and French colonial monitor gunboats. Yet the arsenal also included purpose-built vessels such as the Patrol Boat, River (PBR) whose shallow draft, a high-speed of 25 knots, and armament of machine guns and grenade launchers made it an ideal river assault craft.

The US launched Operation Game Warden in 1966, aimed at stopping and searching vessels along the Mekong waterways. These patrols could be violent affairs—in 1967 alone Game Warden operations destroyed 2,000 enemy vessels, and boarded around 400,000. Yet US forces soon sought more aggressive solutions. The result was the creation of the Mobile Riverine Force a joint army-navy unit dedicated to search-and-destroy operations. Soldiers (principally the 9th Infantry Division) were carried into battle in Armored Troop Carriers (ATCs), with fire support from gun-bristling monitor gunboats. Headquarters were created from floating base ships—often converted LSTs (Landing Ships, Tank) left over from World War II. Pontoons provided platforms for floating artillery firebases.

The Mobile Riverine Force was critical in curtailing Viet Cong influence in the Mekong, particularly during the Communist Tet offensive of 1968, when the riverine craft were used to deploy troops around South Vietnam to douse the fires of Viet Cong uprisings. In 1969 the MRF was reorganized under the SEALORDS program (the Southeast Asia Lake, Ocean, River, and Delta Strategy). The 9th Infantry were detached for other land warfare duties, but the boat force grew in scale and included the now 258-boat strong RPF.



Slow but sure
The turtle emblem on this uniform patch is an affectionate nod to the armored monitor gunboats used by riverine units in Vietnam.

1943–PRESENT

JOHN KERRY

SWIFT BOAT COMMANDER AND ANTI-WAR ACTIVIST

Future US Senator and presidential candidate John Kerry served in Vietnam from 1968–1970, his first tour of duty being aboard the frigate USS *Gridley*. Kerry voluntarily transferred to be the commander of a Patrol Craft, Fast (PCF) Swift boat, performing coastal and river interdiction. In this role he saw much action, receiving three Purple Hearts for wounds sustained in action. After leaving Vietnam, Kerry became an antiwar activist and was the first Vietnam veteran to testify about the war before Congress.

